

THE PANTANAL

The world's largest wetland

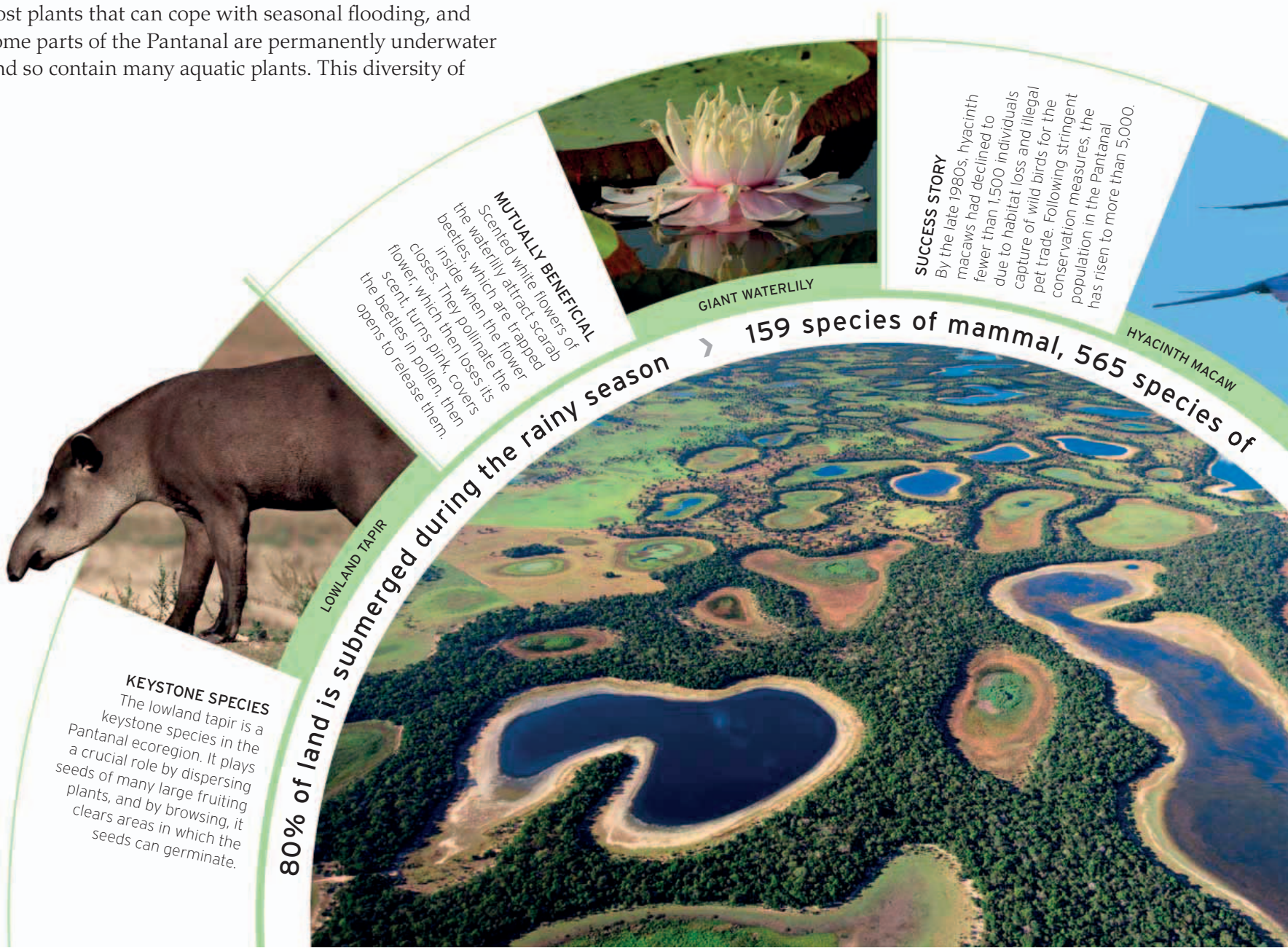
The Pantanal is a vast area of tropical wetland, or swamp, making up 3 percent of the world's wetlands and spreading across 70,000 sq miles (approximately 180,000 sq km). It receives water from the Brazilian highlands and drains into the Paraguay River. Rich, silty soils support a broad complex of plants from the different ecoregions that surround the Pantanal, including the Amazon rainforest to the north and the Cerrado savanna to the east.

Wet and dry

Plant diversity in the Pantanal is particularly great because higher areas remain dry all year round and so maintain drought-tolerant trees, while lower-lying areas host plants that can cope with seasonal flooding, and some parts of the Pantanal are permanently underwater and so contain many aquatic plants. This diversity of

plant life presents great opportunities for animals in the region. However, there are few endemic species in the Pantanal, meaning that many of the animals are also found in neighboring ecoregions. This includes the Yacare caiman, although the Pantanal is its stronghold.

Wetlands act as natural water treatment systems, filtering and removing chemicals from the water, but they are susceptible to pollution from excessive run-off from agriculture and mining activities. Deforestation, infrastructure development, and cattle ranching also risk changing the Pantanal's water resources and so could alter its ecological balance.



MUTUALLY BENEFICIAL
Scented white flowers of the waterlily attract scarab beetles, which are trapped inside when the flower closes. They pollinate the flower, which then loses its scent, turns pink, covers the beetles in pollen, then opens to release them.

GIANT WATERLILY

SUCCESS STORY

By the late 1980s, hyacinth macaws had declined to fewer than 1,500 individuals due to habitat loss and illegal capture of wild birds for the pet trade. Following stringent conservation measures, the population in the Pantanal has risen to more than 5,000.

HYACINTH MACAW

159 species of mammal, 565 species of

LOWLAND TAPIR

KEYSTONE SPECIES
The lowland tapir is a keystone species in the Pantanal ecoregion. It plays a crucial role by dispersing seeds of many large fruiting plants, and by browsing, it clears areas in which the seeds can germinate.

80% of land is submerged during the rainy season